SQL + POWER BI

# If I Started Learning Power BI & SQL Again in 2026, I'd Do This First

The order I would learn in, the first 3 things I would do in week 1, what I would skip, and the one project that ties SQL and Power BI together.

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# The 3 things I would do first

Before any course. These set up everything else.

### 1. Pick one real dataset and stick with it

A sales or e-commerce dataset with orders, customers and products. Use it for both SQL and Power BI, so you learn tools, not datasets.

### 2. Write 10 business questions about it

"Which city brings the most revenue?" "Who stopped ordering?" Every lesson you take, use it to answer one of these.

### 3. Install both tools on day 1

PostgreSQL (or MySQL) and Power BI Desktop. Load the same data into both.

**Why: learning with your own questions makes the skill stick. Courses teach syntax. Questions teach the job.**

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# The order: SQL first, then Power BI

Power BI is much easier once you can think in tables and joins.

- **Weeks 1-2: SQL basics**

  SELECT, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY. Answer 5 of your 10 questions.

- **Weeks 3-4: SQL joins and windows**

  LEFT JOIN, anti join, CTEs, ROW_NUMBER, LAG. Answer the rest.

- **Weeks 5-6: Power BI model and DAX**

  Load the same data, build a star schema, write 10 measures.

- **Weeks 7-8: The project**

  One dashboard that answers your 10 questions, with SQL doing the heavy lifting.

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# SQL: what to learn first

In this order. Each one builds on the last.

- **Filtering and sorting**

  WHERE, IN, BETWEEN, LIKE, IS NULL, ORDER BY.

- **Aggregation**

  COUNT, SUM, AVG with GROUP BY and HAVING.

- **Joins**

  INNER, LEFT, and LEFT JOIN with IS NULL to find missing records.

- **CTEs**

  Break long queries into named steps. Makes everything after this easier.

- **Window functions**

  ROW_NUMBER, RANK, LAG, SUM() OVER. The most asked interview topic.

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# Power BI: what to learn first

Skip fancy visuals. Learn the parts that make reports correct.

## Power Query

Clean types, remove duplicates, unpivot. Do cleaning here, not in DAX.

## Star schema

One fact table, dimension tables, one-to-many relationships, a Date table.

## Core DAX

SUM, DIVIDE, CALCULATE, ALL. Then time intelligence: YTD, last year, YoY %.

## 6 visuals

Card, line, bar, matrix, slicer, line-and-column. Enough for almost every dashboard.

## Publish and share

Power BI Service, scheduled refresh, Row Level Security basics.

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# What I would skip in 2026

Things that take time and rarely show up in analyst jobs or interviews.

- **Memorising syntax**

  AI tools write syntax. Spend the time understanding what the query does and checking the result.

- **Every DAX function**

  Learn 15 well. CALCULATE and filter context matter more than 100 functions.

- **Database administration**

  Indexes and tuning are good to know later. Not needed to get your first analyst role.

- **Certificates before a project**

  One strong project gets more interviews than three certificates.

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# The one project that ties both together

This is what I would put first on my resume.

- **SQL layer**

  Write views that clean and join raw tables: sales_clean, customer_summary, monthly_revenue.

- **Power BI layer**

  Connect to those views. Build the star schema and 10 measures on top.

- **The dashboard**

  KPI cards, revenue trend vs last year, revenue by region, top customers, churned customers.

- **The write-up**

  A short README: 10 questions, the answers, and 3 recommendations for the business.

**Interview line: "I did the heavy transformations in SQL views and kept DAX for business measures, so the model stays fast and simple."**

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# How to use AI while learning

In 2026 this is a real advantage if you use it correctly.

## Write first, then ask

Write your query or measure, then ask AI to review it. Do not start by asking for the answer.

## Ask it to explain

"Explain line by line what this query does and when it would give a wrong result."

## Generate practice

"Give me 10 SQL questions on this schema, from easy to hard, without answers."

## Always check the numbers

AI can write a query that runs and returns the wrong total. Verify against a known figure.

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